



FIVE METAL MASONRY

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ICONOGRAPHY ARCHIVE

Objective, Functional Requirements & Recommended Technology Stack

This document defines the operational and technology foundation for a dedicated online archive of Five Metal Masonry's iconography studies. It intentionally does not define the archive's content architecture, taxonomy, navigation or visual design; those will be developed separately.

1. Objective of the Archive

The objective is to create a dedicated, searchable and sustainable online repository for the iconography studies currently published primarily through social media. The archive should provide a more permanent and structured destination for serious enthusiasts, students and other interested readers, while remaining operationally independent from the Five Metal Masonry ecommerce store.

- Preserve and make the existing body of iconography studies accessible outside social media.
- Provide a dedicated searchable web destination under the Five Metal Masonry domain.
- Support both publicly accessible and member-only material.
- Allow paid archive access without introducing a second ecommerce platform or an unnecessarily expensive subscription stack.
- Support image-heavy studies efficiently.
- Remain scalable so hosting, storage and membership capability can be upgraded as usage grows.
- Keep ongoing technology cost and administrative effort low.
- Avoid custom development wherever a stable, supported off-the-shelf solution is available.

2. Overall Functional Requirements

The following are the high-level functional requirements from an operational and technology perspective. Detailed content architecture will be specified separately.

Publishing & archive operation

- A standalone WordPress-based archive, separate from the existing Shopify ecommerce site.
- Support for image-heavy posts and studies, with responsive images and media management.
- Search capability across archive content; detailed search/filter architecture to be defined separately.
- Ability to publish public content as well as protected member-only content.
- Administrative publishing through the standard WordPress dashboard, without coding.

Membership & payments

- Member registration, login, account management and password recovery.
- Paid membership access with automatic granting and withdrawal of protected-content access.
- Support for finite annual memberships and, if required later, automatic recurring subscriptions.
- Razorpay as the preferred payment gateway, using the existing merchant relationship.
- Member self-service for appropriate actions such as cancellation and membership status viewing.
- Automated handling of membership expiry and failed-payment access rules.
- No custom API or webhook development as part of the normal operating model.

Email & communication

- Automated registration, payment, password, membership-expiry and renewal-related emails.
- Reliable SMTP-based delivery rather than dependence on default web-server mail.
- A dedicated archive sender/reply identity such as archive@fivemetalmasonry.com.
- Replies to the archive address should arrive in the existing Google Workspace/Gmail environment.

Infrastructure, security & continuity

- HTTPS/SSL throughout the archive.
- Hosting-level security and malware protection.
- Regular automatic backups with straightforward restore capability.
- WordPress and plugin updates maintained without server administration.
- Ability to upgrade hosting/storage later without rebuilding the archive.
- Google Analytics and Google Search Console integration for traffic and search visibility.

3. Recommended Technology Stack

Function	Recommendation	Rationale / Cost Position
Domain	Existing fivemetalmasonry.com	No new domain required.
DNS / registrar	Squarespace	Existing setup remains unchanged.
Archive address	archive.fivemetalmasonry.com	Subdomain; no separate registration fee.
Hosting	Hostinger Single	Low-cost starting plan; upgrade later if storage or traffic requires it.
CMS	WordPress.org	Free, self-hosted and unrestricted plugin ecosystem.
Membership	ARMember Standard	Access control, member accounts and recurring/finite plans without WooCommerce.
Payments	Razorpay	Existing gateway; transaction charges only. ARMember provides Razorpay integration.
Transactional email	Brevo SMTP - Free tier	Reliable delivery; free tier is sufficient for expected launch volumes.
Mailbox / replies	Google Workspace / Gmail	Use archive@fivemetalmasonry.com as an alias; no additional mailbox required.
Media storage	Hostinger / WordPress initially	Suitable for launch; optimise images and upgrade/offload media only if growth requires it.
SSL / HTTPS	Hostinger included SSL	No separate certificate purchase expected.
Backups	Hostinger automatic backups	Weekly backups on Single are adequate initially; reassess daily/off-site backup after paid membership grows.
Security	Hostinger + WordPress hardening	No paid security suite recommended at launch.
Analytics	Google Analytics	Free.
Search indexing	Google Search Console	Free; indexing policy to follow content-access decisions.

4. Recommended Membership Approach

ARMember is the current recommended membership layer because it combines member registration, access restriction, membership-plan management and Razorpay integration in a single supported WordPress product. This avoids the much more expensive WooCommerce Memberships + WooCommerce Subscriptions stack and avoids custom development.

- Start with a straightforward annual membership model.
- ARMember can support finite-duration access as well as recurring plans if automatic renewal is introduced.
- Configure access to continue through the paid period when a member cancels, then end at the term boundary.
- Configure failed-payment and expiry actions so access changes automatically rather than requiring manual administration.
- International recurring Razorpay transactions should be tested end-to-end before launch.

5. Cost-Control Principles

The technology stack should remain proportionate to an archive rather than replicate the cost structure of a full ecommerce operation.

- Begin with Hostinger Single and upgrade only when storage, file-count or performance data demonstrates a need.
- Use WordPress.org rather than a hosted platform tier that could constrain plugins or payment integration.
- Avoid WooCommerce unless a future requirement genuinely needs ecommerce functionality.
- Use the existing Razorpay account rather than adding another payment processor without a clear benefit.
- Use Brevo's free transactional-email tier initially.
- Use a Google Workspace alias rather than purchasing a separate mailbox.
- Do not buy paid backup or security plugins at launch unless a specific gap is identified.
- Prefer supported plugins over custom development, even where a small licence cost is involved.

6. Components Deliberately Excluded

- Shopify as the archive platform - the existing ecommerce store remains separate.
- WordPress.com - self-hosted WordPress.org provides greater plugin/payment flexibility and cost control.
- WooCommerce Memberships and WooCommerce Subscriptions - disproportionate annual licence cost for the current requirement.
- Stripe - not required while Razorpay meets the payment requirement.
- Custom API/webhook development - explicitly avoided to minimise technical maintenance.
- Separate paid email mailbox - unnecessary with the existing Google Workspace setup.

7. Implementation Sequence

- Purchase the selected Hostinger Single plan.
- Install a clean WordPress.org instance.
- Create/connect archive.fivemetalmasonry.com through Squarespace DNS.
- Confirm SSL/HTTPS and basic hosting security.
- Install and configure ARMember.
- Connect and test Razorpay, including membership activation, expiry/cancellation and failed-payment behaviour.
- Configure archive@fivemetalmasonry.com in Google Workspace/Gmail.
- Configure Brevo SMTP and test all transactional emails.
- Configure backup/restore and WordPress update practices.
- Connect Google Analytics and Search Console.
- Complete content architecture, visual design and archive population in the separate design/content workstream.
- Perform full desktop/mobile, membership, payment, email, backup and access-control testing before launch.

8. Decisions Deferred to the Content Architecture Workstream

This technology brief intentionally leaves the following open: archive taxonomy, content hierarchy, individual record structure, search facets/filters, navigation, visual design, treatment of Instagram carousels, public-versus-member content strategy, and detailed SEO/content architecture.

Current operational conclusion: the proposed stack is deliberately lean: Squarespace DNS + Hostinger Single + WordPress.org + ARMember + Razorpay + Brevo + Google Workspace. It provides a low-cost starting point with a clear upgrade path and avoids custom development.